MINISTRY OF HIGHER EDUCATION
DEPARTMENT OF HIGHER EDUCATION

GENERAL STUDIES SUBJECT (MPU)
MALAYSIA CITRA

TOPIC 1

INTRODUCTION TO MALAYSIA: HISTORY AND GEOGRAPHY

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SYNOPSIS

This topic provides an introductory exploration into Malaysia, highlighting its rich historical and geographical aspects. It begins by outlining the **Historical Background of Malaysia**, emphasizing the significant event of **Independence Day**, celebrated on August 31, 1957, marking the nation's freedom from British colonial rule. Following this, the discussion progresses into the **Formation of Modern Malaysia**, detailing the pivotal events leading to the federation's establishment on September 16, 1963, through the union of Malaya, Sabah, Sarawak, and Singapore. Finally, the topic explores Malaysia's **Geographical Diversity and Natural Resources**, showcasing its varied landscapes from lush rainforests and mountainous terrains to extensive coastlines, as well as its abundant resources, including tin, petroleum, palm oil, and rubber, all contributing significantly to its economy and cultural heritage.

TOPIC LEARNING OUTCOME

Upon completion of this topic, students will be able to:

01

Explain the **historical background** of Malaysia.



02

Describe the **formation of modern Malaysia.**



03

Show the **geographical diversity and natural resources** of Malaysia.



INTRODUCTION

THIS TOPIC EXPLORES MALAYSIA THROUGH **TWO MAIN PERSPECTIVES:**

HISTORY

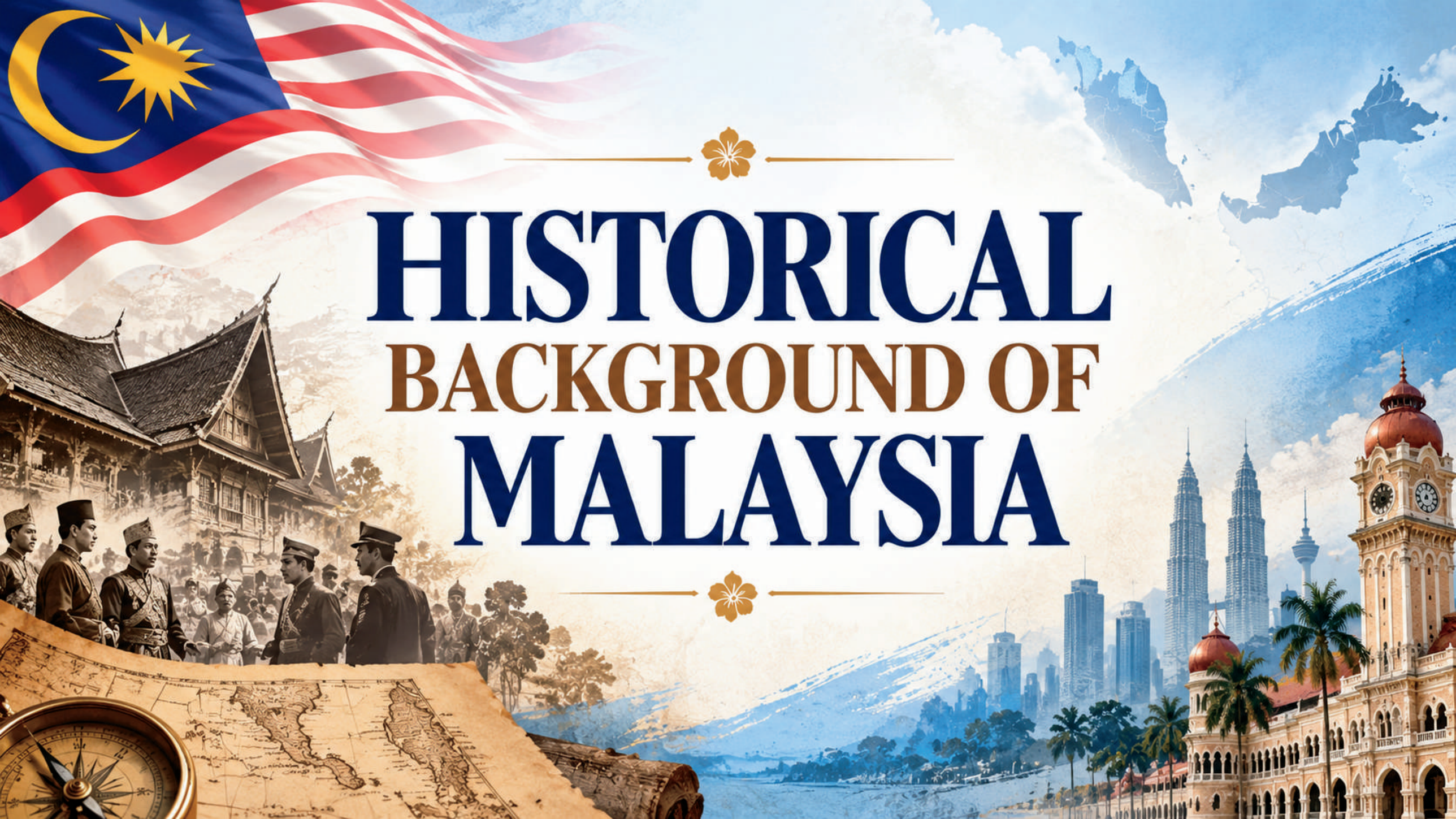
- Malaysia has a complex historical background – local and external influences.
- The chronology of history;
  - Malay Sultanate
  - Colonisation
  - Federation of Malaya 1957
  - Formation of Malaysia 1963



GEOGRAPHY

- Geographical – strategically located
- Divided into two main regions: Peninsular Malaysia and East Malaysia (Sarawak and Sabah)
- Diverse physical landscapes
- Equatorial climate
- Rich in natural resources




HISTORICAL
BACKGROUND OF
MALAYSIA

MALAYSIA'S HISTORICAL JOURNEY

Malaysia's history developed through a series of important political and social transformations, from the early Malay Sultanates to the formation of modern Malaysia in 1963.

01 MALAY SULTANATES



02 FOREIGN COLONISATION



03 STRUGGLE FOR INDEPENDENCE



04 INDEPENDENCE 1957



05 FROM MALAYA TO MALAYSIA 1957 – 1963



06 FORMATION OF MALAYSIA 1963





01 THE GOLDEN AGE OF THE MALAY SULTANATES



Melaka Sultanate



- The existence of Malay sultanates demonstrates that local societies had already developed a highly advanced system of civilisation prior to the arrival of colonial powers.

Other Malay Sultanates and Kingdoms



- Encompassing various aspects – administration, law, trade, literature, sociocultural and others.

Regions of the Melaka Empire



Advanced System of Civilisation

- Administration
- Law
- Trade
- Literature
- Sociocultural Life





02

FROM COLONISATION TO INDEPENDENCE

A BRIEF OVERVIEW OF MALAYA'S HISTORY



PORTUGUESE RULE

1511 – 1641

- Captured Melaka in 1511 and controlled the **strategic trading port.**



DUTCH RULE

1641 – 1824

- Took control of Melaka from the Portuguese and continued to use it as an **important trading centre.**



ANGLO-DUTCH TREATY 1824

17 March 1824

- Divided the region along the Straits of Malacca and the Singapore Strait, placing the **Malay Peninsula and Singapore under British influence and the islands south of the strait (including Sumatra) under Dutch control.**
- The British ceded **Bencoolen (Bengkulu on Sumatra)** to the Dutch, and the Dutch surrendered **Malacca and all claims to Singapore to the British.**

Approximate division of British and Dutch spheres of influence (1824)



Source: Cheah Boon Kheng (2002). *A History of Modern Malaysia* (3rd ed.). Pearson.

BRITISH RULE

1824 – 1941

- British influence expanded across Malaya, developing its **administration, economy and infrastructure,** especially through tin and rubber.



JAPANESE OCCUPATION

1941 – 1945

- Japanese forces occupied Malaya during World War II, bringing a **harsh military rule.**
- The local population suffered greatly due to **forced labour, food shortages, oppression and violence.**



BRITISH RETURN AFTER WWII

1945 – 1957

- After Japan's surrender in 1945, the British returned to **restore administration** in Malaya.



TOWARDS INDEPENDENCE

Post-1945 – 1957

- The Malayan people became more politically aware and formed organisations and movements to demand **self-government and independence.**



After centuries of foreign influence and colonial rule, Malaya entered a new phase — **the struggle towards independence.**

Source: *National Archives of Malaysia (Arkib Negara Malaysia). Anglo-Dutch Treaty (Treaty of London), 17 March 1824.*



03 STRUGGLE FOR INDEPENDENCE

MALAYA (POST-WWII TO 1957)



1. LOCAL RESISTANCE AGAINST COLONIAL RULE

- Resistance occurred in **several Malay states** against foreign interference and colonial rule.
- Involved **Malay leaders and local communities,** such as:



Dol Said



Dato' Maharaja Lela



Tok Janggut



Mat Kilau



Rentap



Mat Salleh

2. GROWTH OF POLITICAL AWARENESS

- **Education, newspapers** and **associations** helped to build a sense of **nationalism** among the people of Malaya.
- Political organisations and leaders emerged to voice the demand for **self-government and independence.**



3. TOWARDS INDEPENDENCE

- After the Japanese surrender in 1945, the British returned to Malaya.
- Political organisation became stronger, and the **demand for self-government grew.**
- Independence was achieved through the efforts of **the people, political leadership** and **negotiations** with the British.



The struggle evolved from **local resistance** against colonial rule into an **organised political movement for independence.**



04

THE ROAD TO INDEPENDENCE

MALAYA (1955 – 1957)

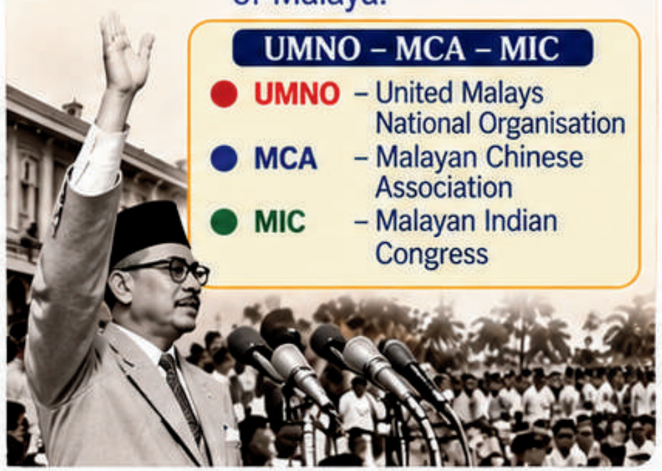


1955
FEDERAL ELECTION

- The Alliance Party (UMNO–MCA–MIC) won **51 of the 52 seats** in the Federal Legislative Council.
- Tunku Abdul Rahman became the **Chief Minister** of Malaya.

UMNO – MCA – MIC

- **UMNO** – United Malays National Organisation
- **MCA** – Malayan Chinese Association
- **MIC** – Malayan Indian Congress



1956
INDEPENDENCE NEGOTIATIONS

- Tunku Abdul Rahman led a delegation to London to **negotiate Malaya's independence** with the British government.
- An **agreement** was reached **in principle** for Malaya to gain independence.



1956 – 1957
REID COMMISSION

- The Reid Commission was established to **draft a Constitution** for an independent Malaya.
- It studied Malaya's political, social and economic conditions and **proposed the framework** for the new Constitution.



31 AUGUST 1957
INDEPENDENCE

- The Federation of Malaya achieved independence on **31 August 1957.**
- Tunku Abdul Rahman became the first **Prime Minister** of the Federation of Malaya.



Through political unity, negotiations and constitutional development, **Malaya achieved its independence on 31 August 1957.**



05

FROM MALAYA TO MALAYSIA



1957
INDEPENDENCE OF MALAYA

- The Federation of Malaya achieved independence on **31 August 1957.**
- Tunku Abdul Rahman became the **first Prime Minister.**



Independent Malaya was an important milestone,

but this was NOT yet Malaysia.

In 1963, a new federation called Malaysia was formed, bringing together Malaya, Sarawak, Sabah and Singapore.

1963
FORMATION OF MALAYSIA

- A new federation called Malaysia was formed on **16 September 1963.**
- It brought together Malaya, Sarawak, Sabah and Singapore (which later withdrew in 1965).



How did independent Malaya become Malaysia?

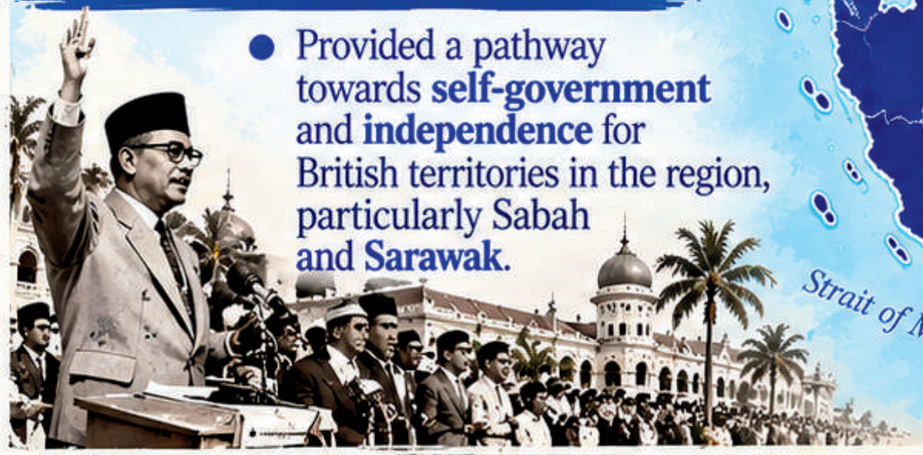


FACTORS BEHIND THE FORMATION OF MALAYSIA

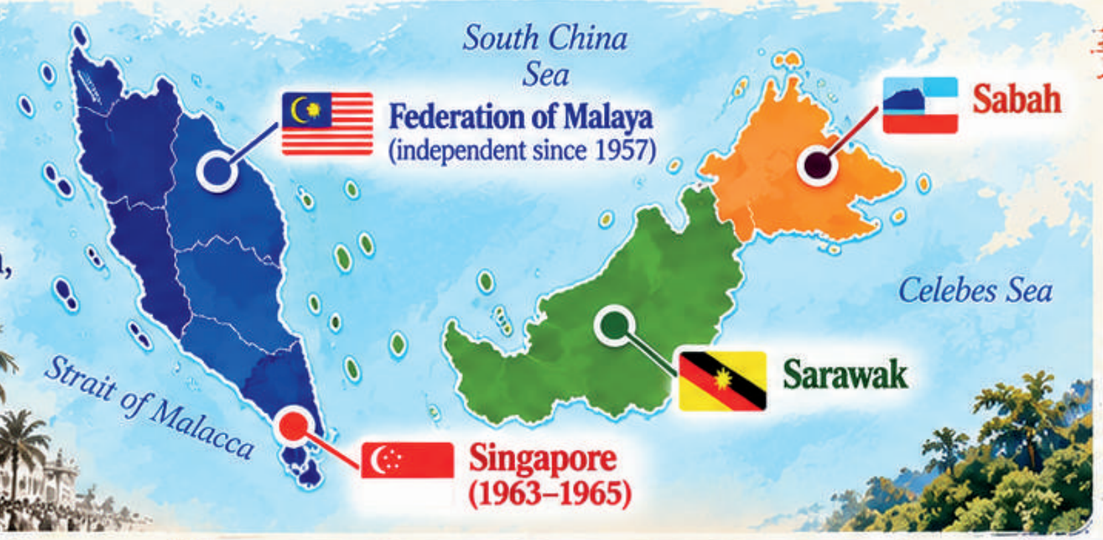


The formation of Malaysia in 1963 was influenced by several key factors, which reflected the political, security, economic and regional considerations of the time.

DECOLONISATION



- Provided a pathway towards **self-government** and **independence** for British territories in the region, particularly Sabah and **Sarawak**.



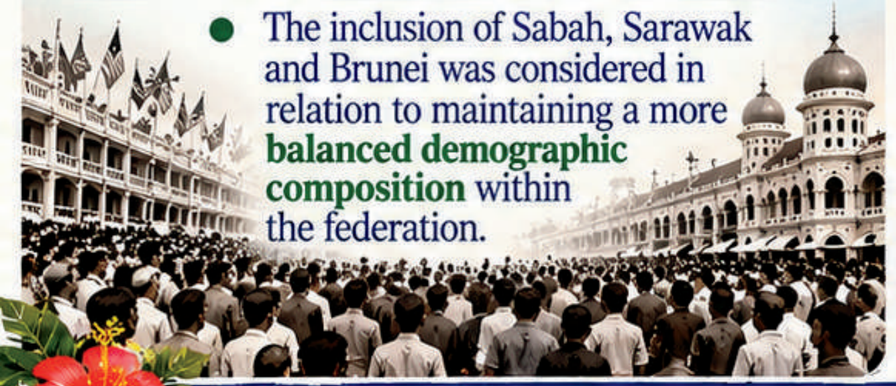
SECURITY & POLITICAL STABILITY

- Concerns over **communist influence** during the Cold War, particularly in Singapore and the region.
- A larger federation was seen as a way to **strengthen regional political stability.**



POPULATION BALANCE

- The inclusion of Sabah, Sarawak and Brunei was considered in relation to maintaining a more **balanced demographic composition** within the federation.



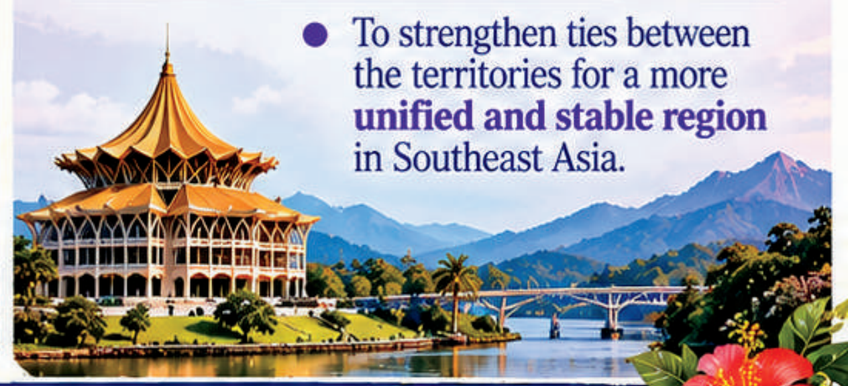
ECONOMIC COOPERATION

- To promote **economic development** through the sharing of resources, larger markets and greater regional cooperation.



REGIONAL COOPERATION

- To strengthen ties between the territories for a more **unified and stable region** in Southeast Asia.



Sources: *National Archives of Malaysia (Arkib Negara Malaysia); Penubuhan Malaysia 16 September 1963; Dari Malaya ke Malaysia; Parliament of Singapore; Historical Development; Singapore Statutes Online, Republic of Singapore Independence Act 1965.*

KEY MILESTONES TOWARDS THE FORMATION OF MALAYSIA



1961

Tunku Abdul Rahman proposed the formation of Malaysia.

The proposal involved Malaya, Singapore, Sarawak, Sabah and Brunei.



1962

Consultation and assessment by the Cobbold Commission in Sabah and Sarawak.

To get the views of the people of Sabah and Sarawak on the proposal.



9 July 1963

The Malaysia Agreement was signed by the United Kingdom, Federation of Malaya, North Borneo (Sabah), Sarawak and Singapore.



16 September 1963

Malaysia officially formed.

Bringing together Malaya, Sabah, Sarawak and Singapore.

REACTIONS TO THE FORMATION PLAN

The proposal to form Malaysia in 1963 was influenced by several key factors, which reflected the political, security, economic and regional considerations of the time.

MALAYSIA IN 1963

Federation of Malaya
– independent since 1957.

- The Malayan government, led by Tunku Abdul Rahman, proposed the formation of Malaysia in 1961.



Sabah

- Public opinion was assessed through consultation.
- The Cobbold Commission gathered views on the Malaysia proposal.
- Concerns included safeguards, autonomy and local interests.

Singapore

- Supportive at first and joined Malaysia in 1963.
- Differences in political and economic interests later led to Singapore's separation on **9 AUGUST 1965.**

Sarawak

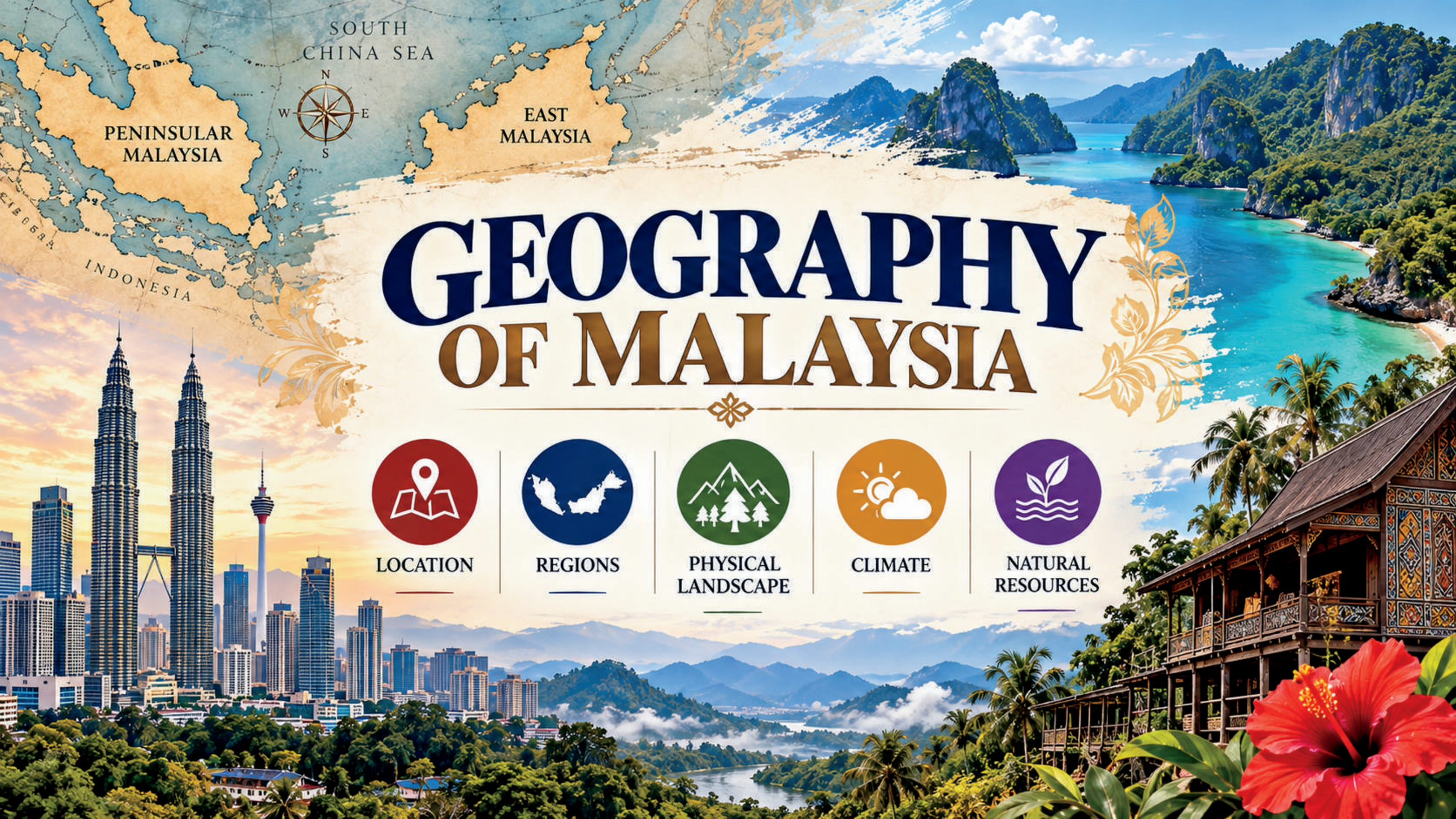
- Public opinion was assessed through consultation.
- The Cobbold Commission gathered views on the Malaysia proposal.
- Concerns included safeguards, autonomy and local interests.

Brunei

- Initially considered joining Malaysia.
- Later decided not to join due to concerns over sovereignty, autonomy and internal factors.

Sources: *National Archives of Malaysia (Arkib Negara Malaysia), Penubuhan Malaysia 16 September 1963; Dari Malaya ke Malaysia; Parliament of Singapore; Historical Development; Singapore Statutes Online, Republic of Singapore Independence Act 1965.*


THE STATES OF
MALAYSIA
Malaysia consists of 13 states and 3 federal territories, located in Peninsular Malaysia and East Malaysia, with diverse landscapes, cultures and natural resources.
N
W
E
S
Perlis
Kedah
Pulau Pinang
Perak
Kelantan
Terengganu
Pahang
Selangor
Negeri Sembilan
Melaka
Johor
PENINSULAR MALAYSIA
11 states
EAST MALAYSIA
2 states
Sabah
Sarawak
South China Sea
Celebes Sea
Strait of Malacca
0 100 200 300 400 500 500 km
FEDERAL TERRITORIES
(3 Federal Territories)
Kuala Lumpur, Putrajaya & Labuan


SOUTH
CHINA SEA
N
W
E
S
PENINSULAR
MALAYSIA
EAST
MALAYSIA
INDONESIA
GEOGRAPHY
OF MALAYSIA
LOCATION
REGIONS
PHYSICAL
LANDSCAPE
CLIMATE
NATURAL
RESOURCES

WHERE IS MALAYSIA?

Location and Regions

Southeast Asia

Malaysia is located in Southeast Asia, bordering Thailand, Indonesia, Brunei and Singapore, and surrounded by the South China Sea and the Straits of Malacca.

Near the Equator

Malaysia lies close to the Equator, at about 1°N – 7°N latitude. Its strategic location influences its tropical climate, natural environment and diverse culture.

Two Geographical Regions

Malaysia consists of two separated regions: Peninsular Malaysia (West Malaysia) on the mainland of Southeast Asia, and East Malaysia on the island of Borneo.

Strategic Location

Malaysia is situated along important sea routes, including the Straits of Malacca and the South China Sea, which have historically made it a significant centre for trade and cultural exchange.



Source: Government of Malaysia, MyGovernment (2026)

PHYSICAL LANDSCAPE OF MALAYSIA



MOUNTAINS & HIGHLANDS

- Mountainous areas are found in both Peninsular Malaysia and East Malaysia.
- **Mount Kinabalu** in Sabah (4,095 metres) is the highest mountain in Malaysia.



TROPICAL RAINFORESTS

- Malaysia is covered by extensive **tropical rainforests**, especially in Borneo (Sabah and Sarawak).
- Home to rich biodiversity, including unique flora and fauna.



RIVERS

- Rivers are important features of Malaysia's landscape.
- The **Rajang River** in Sarawak (about 563 km) is the longest river in Malaysia.



COASTLINES & ISLANDS

- Malaysia has a long coastline along the Straits of Malacca, South China Sea and the Celebes Sea.
- There are numerous islands, including popular islands such as **Langkawi, Tioman, Perhentian and Sipadan**.

KEY TAKEAWAY

Malaysia's landscape ranges from **mountains** and **tropical rainforests** to **rivers**, **coastlines and islands**.

CLIMATE OF MALAYSIA

What is the Equator?

The Equator is an imaginary line around the middle of the Earth at **0° latitude**, dividing the Earth into the Northern and Southern Hemispheres.



1 TEMPERATURE

- Typical daytime temperatures: around **26°C – 32°C**.
- Relatively constant temperatures throughout the year.
- Cooler in highland areas such as **Cameron Highland** and **Genting Highlands.**
- Kundasang also experiences cooler temperatures.



2 RAINFALL

- High annual rainfall: about **2,000 – 4,000 mm** (varies by region).
- Rainfall occurs throughout the year.
- Afternoon thunderstorms are common.



3 MONSOON SEASONS

Northeast Monsoon (November – March)

- Brings heavier rainfall especially to the east coast of Peninsular Malaysia, western Sarawak and eastern Sabah.



Southwest Monsoon (late May – September)

- Relatively drier weather.



4 INFLUENCE ON MALAYSIA

- Supports rich biodiversity and tropical rainforests.
- Provides important water resources.
- Supports agriculture (e.g. oil palm, rubber, rice and fruits).
- Influences daily life and economic activities (e.g. agriculture, fisheries, tourism).



KEY TAKEAWAY

Malaysia has a **tropical climate** with generally uniform temperatures, high humidity and abundant rainfall throughout the year.

Source: Malaysian Meteorological Department (METMalaysia), 2026.

NATURAL RESOURCES OF MALAYSIA



PETROLEUM & NATURAL GAS

- Important energy resources for Malaysia.
- Particularly associated with offshore areas of **Sabah**, **Sarawak** and the **east coast of Peninsular Malaysia**.





MINERALS

- **Tin** played an important role in Malaysia's historical economic development.
- Other mineral resources such as bauxite, iron ore, gold and limestone are also found in the country.

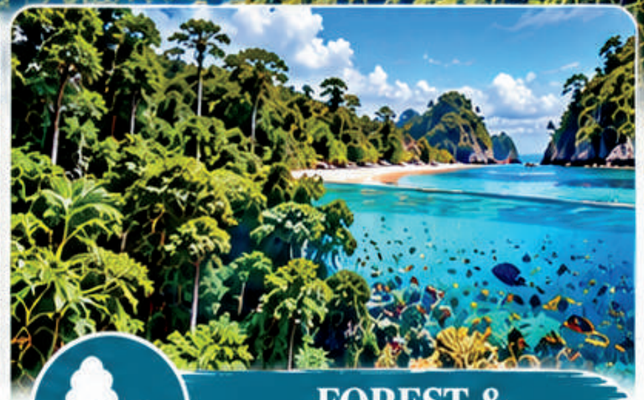




AGRICULTURAL RESOURCES

- **Palm oil** and **rubber** are important agricultural commodities.
- Malaysia's tropical climate supports a variety of crops such as rice, cocoa, pepper, fruits and tropical fruits.





FOREST & MARINE RESOURCES

- Tropical forests provide **timber** and **biodiversity resources**.
- Malaysia's extensive coastline and waters support **fisheries and marine resources**.



KEY TAKEAWAY

Malaysia's natural resources have played an important role in the country's **economic development** and continue to support **various industries and livelihoods**.

CONCLUSION

Malaysia today is shaped by its **historical journey**, the **formation of the nation**, and its unique **geographical environment**.

From its historical development to the formation of Malaysia in 1963, the country has evolved into a nation characterised by geographical diversity and rich natural resources.

Understanding the past and the land helps us better understand Malaysia today.

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